

Yet Grant and his staff remained unaware of the situation on the ground. Barlow's fleeting success only prompted more orders to attack. The result was near mutiny among the generals, and it was midday before Grant finally halted the debacle. By then the full extent of casualties was becoming known. While some Confederate divisions reported no casualties, the Union troops had been decimated. Of the 6,500 to 7,000 men felled during the first hour of battle that morning, most had been hit during the first fatal ten minutes.

BREASTWORK A rapidly constructed, temporary fortification, erected as a defense in battle. The name comes from its walls being breast height.

“I had seen **nothing** to exceed this. It was not war; **it was murder.**”

CONFEDERATE GENERAL EVANDER MCIVOR LAW

The wounded abandoned

Among the casualties were masses of wounded men strewn across the ravaged fields. Still the Confederate gunners kept firing. Survivors could only dig in where they lay, using bayonets and tin cups as entrenching tools. The following day, Grant conferred with Lee about collecting the wounded, who had lain exposed for over 24 hours. Grant refused to ask for a formal truce, and Lee distrusted Grant's motives. For three days, dead bodies lay on the fields. Under cover of darkness some soldiers tried slipping out to recover their moaning comrades. But with the battle lines sometimes only 150ft (45m) apart, sharpshooters dared any man who raised his head. Some tried digging trenches to reach the wounded instead. Finally, on the evening of June 7, Grant asked for a formal truce and Lee agreed. By that time there were few wounded still alive in the fields